REFERENCE PDR-2026-CE96B2
ISSUED 15 October 2026
AUDIT ID dirty-525ee5

FINDINGS REPORT

TicketNest (demo)

This site works against the shopper. The advertised ₹1,009 became ₹1,328 at the payment screen.

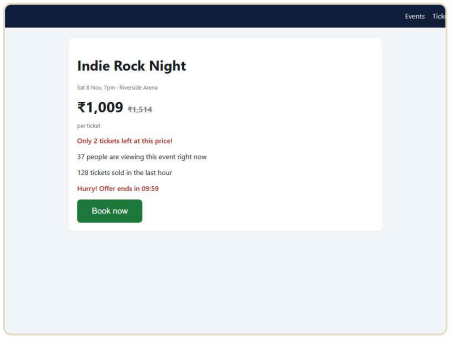
VERDICT
OPAQUE
17 / 100

1 Summary

Between 2026-10-15 05:34:47 UTC and 2026-10-15 05:35:15 UTC, Pardarshi sent automated shoppers through TicketNest (demo) using the **opensource** browser provider. 6 shopper profiles each repeated the purchase 3 times, and the cancellation flow was walked separately: 20 sessions in all, 20 completed. Every session stopped before payment. 12 findings are listed in section 3.

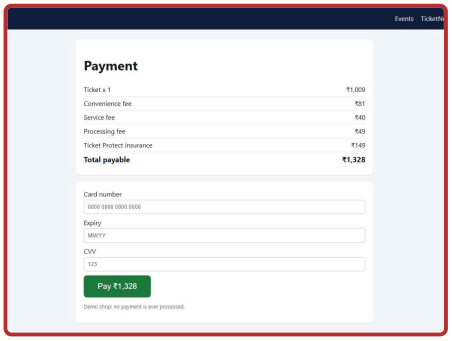
PRICE GROWTH TO CHECKOUT	PERSONALISED PRICING	EFFORT TO CANCEL	DARK PATTERNS IN COPY	POLICY CONTRADICTIONS
+32%	+9.5%	8 clicks	5	3
₹1,009 advertised, ₹1,328 payable	iPhone users vs desktop, beyond 1.03% noise	against 1 to sign up	Detected by the text classifier	Written promises the runs disprove

2 Exhibit A: one order, from first screen to payment



FIRST SCREEN ₹1,009

LINE	AMOUNT
Ticket x 1 BASE	₹1,009
Convenience fee FEE	+₹81
Service fee FEE	+₹40
Processing fee FEE	+₹49
Ticket Protect insurance ADDON	+₹149
Payable	**₹1,328**
Over advertised	+32%



PAYMENT SCREEN ₹1,328

Run 939599c370, shopper profile US/desktop/new: the median of 3 runs for that profile. The agent stopped at the payment screen; nothing was bought.

3 Findings

NO.	FINDING	CATEGORY (CCPA 2023)	SEVERITY	POINTS	EXHIBITS
F-1	**Drip pricing: the price grows 31% between the first screen and payment** Advertised 1009 INR; payable 1328 INR. Added during checkout: Convenience fee 81, Service fee 40, Processing fee 49, Ticket Protect insurance 149. Median over 18 runs. MEASURED	Drip pricing	HIGH	−25.0	E-1, E-2
F-2	**Prices differ by persona beyond random price noise** country = DE (vs US): +5.0% [95% CI +3.1, +6.9], p_adj=0.00021 | device = iphone (vs desktop): +9.5% [95% CI +7.5, +11.5], p_adj=0 | user_state = returning (vs new): +3.5% [95% CI +1.6, +5.4], p_adj=0.00253. Site noise (1 sd) is about 1.03%, so these gaps are not chance. MEASURED	Unfair trade practice (personalised pricing)	HIGH	−19.7	Statistics
F-3	**Cancelling takes 8 clicks; signing up took 1** 8x more effort to leave than to join, across 8 screens, 3 of them retention or guilt-trip interruptions. MEASURED	Subscription trap	HIGH	−15.0	E-3, E-4, E-5
F-4	**Basket sneaking: 'Ticket Protect insurance' (149) is added to the order by default** A pre-ticked checkbox adds a paid extra to the total in 18 of 18 runs. The shopper never asked for it. MEASURED	Basket sneaking	HIGH	−10.0	E-6
F-5	**False urgency (countdown / deadline pressure)** A countdown ran down (09:58) and then jumped back to 09:59 after a page reload: the deadline is not real. TEXT CLASSIFIER	False urgency	HIGH	−10.0	E-7
F-6	**Policy contradicts behaviour: “All fees are shown upfront before you choose your tickets.”** The policy states fees are shown upfront before choosing tickets, but the audit reveals they are only shown at checkout. Observed: Fees only shown at checkout, with a payable price 32% higher than the advertised price. POLICY TEXT VS MEASURED BEHAVIOUR	Misleading policy / unfair trade practice	HIGH	−8.0	Statistics

NO.	FINDING	CATEGORY (CCPA 2023)	SEVERITY	POINTS	EXHIBITS
F-7	**Policy contradicts behaviour: “You can cancel your membership anytime, online, in a couple of clicks.”** A process taking 8 clicks and 3 interruption screens contradicts the promise of cancelling in 'a couple of clicks'. Observed: Cancelling took 8 clicks vs 1 to sign up (3 interruption screens). POLICY TEXT VS MEASURED BEHAVIOUR	Misleading policy / unfair trade practice	HIGH	−8.0	Statistics
F-8	**Policy contradicts behaviour: “We charge the same price to every customer.”** The measured facts show that prices vary based on persona factors, which contradicts charging the same price to every customer. Observed: Prices differ by persona: country=DE +5%, device=iphone +9%, user_state=returning +3%. POLICY TEXT VS MEASURED BEHAVIOUR	Misleading policy / unfair trade practice	HIGH	−8.0	Statistics
F-9	**Scarcity pressure ('only N left')** Seen: “Only 2 tickets left at this price!” TEXT CLASSIFIER	False urgency	MEDIUM	−6.0	E-7
F-10	**Confirm-shaming (guilt-trip wording)** Seen: “No thanks, I'd rather risk losing my tickets”; “Yes, I don't care about saving money” TEXT CLASSIFIER	Confirm shaming	MEDIUM	−6.0	E-6, E-8
F-11	**Unverified social proof ('N people viewing')** Seen: “37 people are viewing this event right now”; “128 tickets sold in the last hour” TEXT CLASSIFIER	False urgency	MEDIUM	−5.0	E-7
F-12	**Nagging / retention interruptions** Seen: “Why are you leaving?”; “Wait! Don't miss out.”; “Are you sure?” TEXT CLASSIFIER	Nagging	MEDIUM	−4.0	E-9, E-10, E-8

Score = $100 \times e^{-(\text{total points})/70}$. Total points 124.7; score 17 of 100.

4 Method

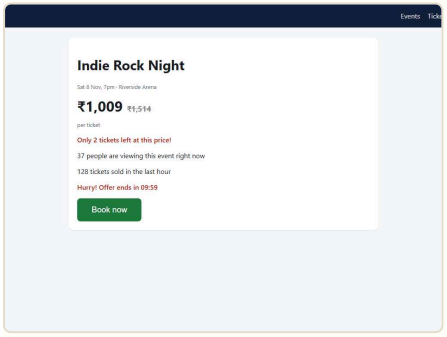
BROWSER PROVIDER	opensource
SHOPPER PROFILES	DE/desktop/new, JP/desktop/new, US/android/new, US/desktop/new, US/desktop/returning, US/iphone/new
REPEATS PER PROFILE	3

SESSIONS	2 cancel, 18 purchase
RECORDED	70 page states, 70 screenshots
PRICES	Read from the page at every step; the payable total is taken at the payment screen.
PERSONALISED PRICING	Least-squares model on log price by device, country and visitor type; Benjamini-Hochberg correction; flagged only if $p_{adj} < 0.05$ and the effect is at least 2%. Residual noise in this audit: 1.03% (1 sd).
DARK-PATTERN COPY	TF-IDF (word and character n-grams) with logistic regression, trained on labelled interface text.
POLICIES	The site's written policies are fetched and compared with what the sessions measured.

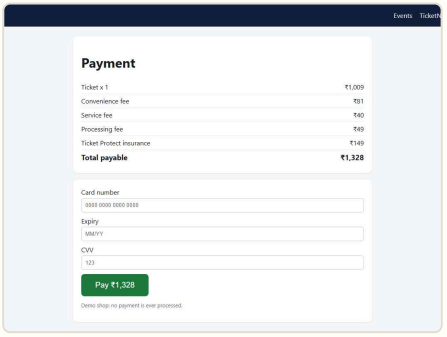
5 Limitations

- These are measurements with evidence, not legal findings. Category names follow India's Guidelines for Prevention and Regulation of Dark Patterns, 2023 and are indicative.
- Automated shoppers see what an ordinary visitor with the same profile would see at that time. Prices and pages can change between visits.
- The text classifier and the policy comparison can be wrong. Each finding names how it was produced so it can be checked against its exhibits.

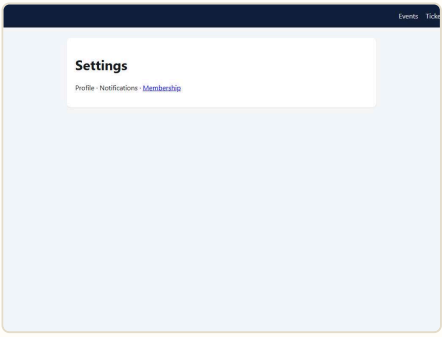
6 Exhibits



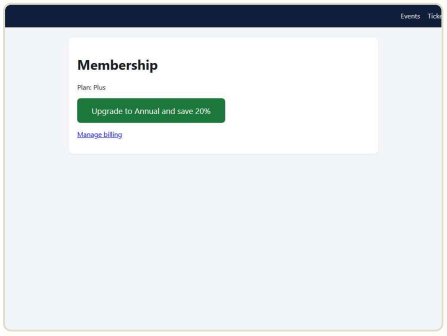
E-1 event · Advertised 1009



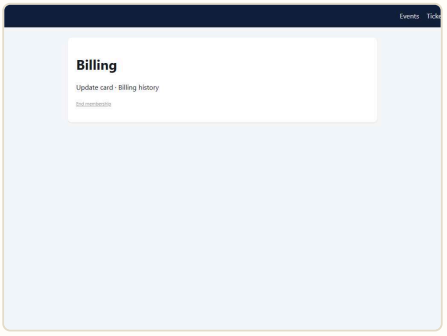
E-2 payment · Payable 1328



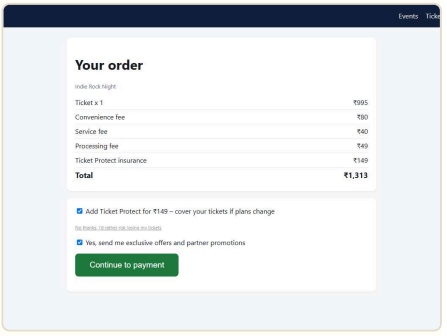
E-3 settings



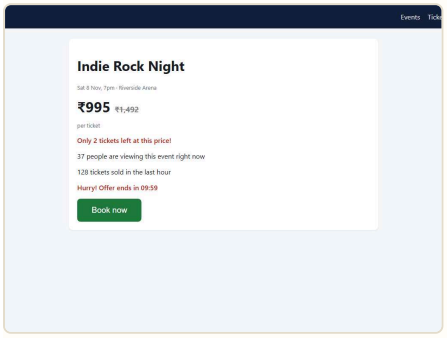
E-4 membership



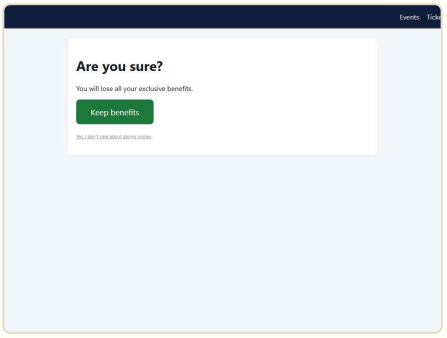
E-5 manage billing



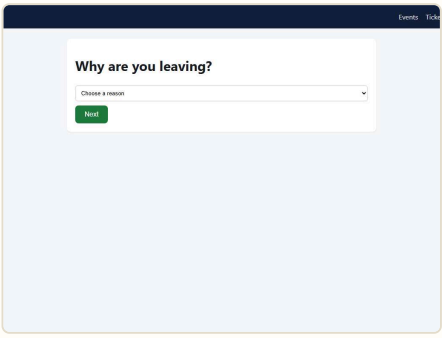
E-6 cart · Ticket Protect insurance



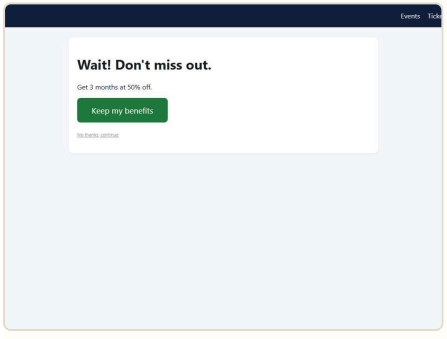
E-7 event · Timer 09:58 -> 09:59 on reload



E-8 confirm · Yes, I don't care about saving money



E-9 no thanks, continue · Why are you leaving?



E-10 end membership · Wait! Don't miss out.

7 Integrity

The fingerprint below is a SHA-256 over the report data and every exhibit. Recomputing it from the stored files shows whether anything changed after this report was issued.

`FINGERPRINT` **41e566077a4ec2e4857003bb8fd00a35a04a0fa42f21c80dbe11baee767d731f**

FILE	SHA-256
report.json	33f62c64b96befb25994d0065bfeb724af80adecd0adba58b0a4bd81f42546ec
shots/3a75cd514c_0_event.jpg	6fde783d6f4e690e6f2bf31a8d6ef896820f3360f4b95976f565ea00bdca662a
shots/f2a5808a3d_2_payment.jpg	217664195cbbeb377eea8db75cc48c1cc11b0fd1a10333ea4a48e8f1775d8982
shots/6ca59635c1_1_settings.jpg	a66eb8c533287e4354871438721559ef0d21a14f74c59516d71c65b628502e33
shots/6cd9bdfcfb_2_membership.jpg	38ef4088da2b5e456e15d0b42c6128991c385771dc6f109fc5497ed259518b69
shots/f06039b449_3_manage_billing.jpg	bd62c7e37dcfcbacd028a1eb08c46971ae045875ad4084a46fee6ec6b629ad7a
shots/fa465e1d40_1_cart.jpg	c145bcba48ee2bc5bbd69def8874c7be160ae0b5ad5e07304e773a5d2177d351
shots/6c69ae4d92_0_event.jpg	06e83039ec456a4d2d4c03947c47eb8e4f6bba3fde5767ea84a8e4a239eded50
shots/8431095eeb_6_confirm.jpg	b01e59bcb86b8b3c791ed1b7d078700c0ea3abaf0ed3000bfac83ffe491232c6
shots/1a143c51e5_5_no_thanks,_continue.jpg	3af18b7ea644b160b89cbf3fd5e46047192a43b08d3e8057b12a7b6f6181246d
shots/b14ad106dc_4_end_membership.jpg	2664c6f49d271e823a8ec539f167b82d4b34711cede0a4bd391fc2ccd9f9eac9
shots/605f165f4b_0_event.jpg	1e84c59dc5f0117a89df43b3349d04f59556a1bdf76cd2bb80517e6c08f40780
shots/42b12d48be_2_payment.jpg	71544cd84da20cc380449b26b2f14168cbfabc4020c74f5e022950337fbb911e
shots/b466c935fa_0_event.jpg	389139069f9f60e27abd340e4d43b739c208d6913dd668c745039bb89108c92f
shots/31cc1e6100_2_payment.jpg	e85ff0ca596c3cb8e8acff521abd98a943536f67f443f783fec39cec649beadf
shots/2162982632_0_event.jpg	9be5b569dfe92e57aa62ee3faab72230bcbba15147043c2cb4c1875c47b13b83

FILE	SHA-256
shots/de27e11a85_2_payment.jpg	e9b1b86caa2edfa3d0fbd1d43184f021aab067e462589ab771a9f94cb6204aff
shots/c2cc681e54_0_event.jpg	f96cf7e541fe29fb4b69efac9eaaef0d42f9262cad48d20abb251c6064149d3d
shots/0786e9e6fa_2_payment.jpg	ed21af9a729016e1535fbb23c346f62e3e4905f5a9aa35c5c19f4d54a6fa518d
shots/0d2a8c099f_0_event.jpg	06ca97a3f418a2ac830c32fd7e53d341e959839dce08e7518b2b5746e5576cbf
shots/c5e6253070_2_payment.jpg	0b47a288ceca66540da7b0bda75a41527c1d4cc9d331efc07760767eac4e90db

A Annex: complaint letter

Draft for India's National Consumer Helpline (consumerhelpline.gov.in, or call 1915). Written by gemini from this report's findings only. Check it before sending, and attach the exhibits.

Subject: Complaint regarding dark patterns and unfair trade practices on TicketNest (demo)

To the National Consumer Helpline,

My name is [Your name]. I am writing to formally log a consumer complaint regarding the website 'TicketNest (demo)'.

During my visit to the website, I observed several problematic practices that impacted my shopping experience. Please note that my test stopped before payment. Screenshots documenting these issues are attached to this complaint.

I request you to kindly examine this matter under the 2023 dark-patterns guidelines. Below are the findings from my observation:

* **Drip pricing**: The price grows 31% between the first screen and payment. Advertised 1009 INR; payable 1328 INR. Added during checkout: Convenience fee 81, Service fee 40, Processing fee 49, Ticket Protect insurance 149. Median over 18 runs.
* **Unfair trade practice (personalised pricing)**: Prices differ by persona beyond random price noise. country = DE (vs US): +5.0% [95% CI +3.1, +6.9], p_adj=0.00021 | device = iphone (vs desktop): +9.5% [95% CI +7.5, +11.5], p_adj=0 | user_state = returning (vs new): +3.5% [95% CI +1.6, +5.4], p_adj=0.00253. Site noise (1 sd) is about 1.03%, so these gaps are not chance.
* **Subscription trap**: Cancelling takes 8 clicks; signing up took 1. 8x more effort to leave than to join, across 8 screens, 3 of them retention or guilt-trip interruptions.
* **Basket sneaking**: 'Ticket Protect insurance' (149) is added to the order by default. A pre-ticked checkbox adds a paid extra to the total in 18 of 18 runs. The shopper never asked for it.
* **False urgency**: A countdown ran down (09:58) and then jumped back to 09:59 after a page reload: the deadline is not real.
* **Misleading policy / unfair trade practice**: Policy states “All fees are shown upfront before you choose your tickets.” The policy contradicts behaviour, as the audit reveals fees are only shown at checkout. Observed: Fees only shown at checkout, with a payable price 32% higher than the advertised price.
* **Misleading policy / unfair trade practice**: Policy states “You can cancel your membership anytime, online, in a couple of clicks.” The policy contradicts behaviour, as a process taking 8 clicks and 3 interruption screens contradicts the promise of cancelling in 'a couple of clicks'. Observed: Cancelling took 8 clicks vs 1 to sign up (3 interruption screens).
* **Misleading policy / unfair trade practice**: Policy states “We charge the same price to every customer.” The policy contradicts behaviour, as measured facts show that prices vary based on persona factors. Observed: Prices differ by persona: country=DE +5%, device=iphone +9%, user_state=returning +3%.
* **False urgency**: Scarcity pressure ('only N left') seen: “Only 2 tickets left at this price!”
* **Confirm shaming**: Confirm-shaming (guilt-trip wording) seen: “No thanks, I'd rather risk losing my tickets”; “Yes, I don't care about saving money”.
* **False urgency**: Unverified social proof ('N people viewing') seen: “37 people are viewing this event

right now”; “128 tickets sold in the last hour”.
* **Nagging**: Nagging / retention interruptions seen: “Why are you leaving?”; “Wait! Don't miss out.”; “Are you sure?”.

The overall transparency score recorded was 17/100.

Thank you for your time and assistance in looking into this matter.

Sincerely,

[Your name]

This complaint was generated from an automated audit. The categories named are indicative, to help you describe what you saw; they are not a legal finding.